

Studying Development of Psychopathology Across the Lifespan

Isaac T. Petersen, Zachary Demko, and Megan Schumer

Department of Psychological and Brain Sciences, University of Iowa

Author Note

Isaac T. Petersen  <https://orcid.org/0000-0003-3072-6673>

Zachary Demko  <https://orcid.org/0000-0002-5717-6205>

Megan Schumer  <https://orcid.org/0009-0009-5488-6541>

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Correspondence concerning this article should be addressed to Isaac T. Petersen, University of Iowa, G60 Psychological and Brain Sciences Building, Iowa City, IA 52242. Email: isaac-t-petersen@uiowa.edu

Abstract

The field has not adequately studied individuals' development of psychopathology across the lifespan, instead taking a piecewise approach to development, limiting our understanding of lifespan development and the origins of psychopathology. We describe why this is the case—beyond logistical challenges. First, diagnostic and taxonomic systems do not define psychopathology constructs from a developmental perspective. A developmental perspective is crucial because psychopathology constructs often have earlier origins than their full clinical presentation, and forms of psychopathology frequently show changes in behavioral manifestation across development (heterotypic continuity). Second, current assessments do not adequately capture these changes in behavioral manifestation. Third, traditional scoring systems do not allow charting individuals' change over time in the face of changing behavioral manifestation. Fourth, assessments are not well-suited for capturing individual differences, despite the dimensional nature of psychopathology. We propose solutions to these challenges by introducing a developmental scaling framework for psychopathology. Using externalizing psychopathology as an example, we draw on our content analysis of externalizing measures, as well as lessons from the study of other constructs across lengthy developmental periods. Addressing these challenges will allow charting individuals' trajectories of psychopathology across the lifespan and identifying risk and protective factors that influence developmental courses.

Keywords: psychopathology, development, lifespan, longitudinal, externalizing behavior problems

Studying Development of Psychopathology Across the Lifespan

The Goal

The Problem/Obstacle

Reasons for the Problem

Solution

Other Key Challenges to Address

Conclusion

Appendix A

This Section Is an Appendix

Appendix B

Another Appendix